Chapter 3

CHANAKYA - ARCHITECT OF A GREATER INDIA

BR. RUPESH KALESAN

Once, at dusk, a foreigner visited his home; Acharya Vishnugupta courteously gestured him to sit down and continued what he was writing. There are disputing claims regarding who that visitor was: some claim it to be Megasthenes, a Greek historian and explorer who visited India, while others say it could have been a Chinese traveller.

Vishnugupta finished his work and wrapped the manuscript in silk, tied the bundle with a string, lit another lamp, and extinguished the flame of the first lamp. He then inquired about the visitor's welfare. Perplexed by what Vishnugupta had just done, the visitor humbly asked, "Why did you extinguish one lamp and light another? Is it some kind of Indian tradition associated with receiving guests cordially?"

Though this incident took place approximately 2,300 years ago, Vishnugupta's answer to that visitor must be remembered and cherished even today.



He said, "Dear friend, this is not a tradition. When you came into my house, I was working on some official documents of my kingdom. The oil for the first lamp has been taken from the government treasury, whereas now I am speaking to you, probably in personal interest. Using government resources or money for unofficial purposes is misappropriation. Therefore, in order to talk to you, I lit another lamp with oil purchased from my personal fund."

This is one of many folklores about Vishnugupta, popularly known as 'Chanakya,' who always prioritised National affairs above personal matters [1].

In the wake of Alexander's retreat from India, a very powerful Indian kingdom emerged.

Around BCE 316, the landmass stretching from the eastern mountain ranges in Myanmar to the western Persian deserts and from the Himalayas in the north to the Vindhyas in the South came

under the rule of a single mighty empire, the Mauryan Empire. When we read about the founder of this empire, Chandragupta Maurya, from the annals of history, let us not forget Chanakya, the kingmaker and doyen of ancient Indian statecraft, who raised an ordinary lad to the level of an unparalleled emperor.

The Rise of Chanakya: From Scholar to Statesman

The sources of information on Vishnugupta's life include Mahavamsha, a Buddhist text composed in the Pali language; Parishishtaparvan, an ancient Sanskrit text about Jain masters; the Kathasaritsagara, a compendium of Kashmiri legends in Sanskrit; and Mudrarakshasa, a Sanskrit play.

Vishnugupta was also called 'Chanakya' because he was the son of Rishi Chanaka. Chanakya studied in Takshashila, the renowned and most ancient university in India. After completing his studies, he remained in Takshashila as a teacher. Chanakya believed that a teacher could claim to have succeeded in his or her mission only if he or she could awaken in students the pride and love for the country.

In those days, the kingdom of Magadha was ruled by the Nanda dynasty. The last Nanda king, Dhana Nanda, was interested only in amassing wealth and living a luxurious life. He even took unfair taxes from his citizens. It was during this time, Seleucus, the Greek general who ruled India's northeast regions, which Alexander had conquered, was preparing to attack the then India. Realising the external and internal security threat confronting the country, Chanakya resigned from Takshshila and travelled to Patliputra, the capital of the Magadha Empire, to address these issues with the king.

His meeting with Dhana Nanda was a great disappointment. The king insulted Chanakya in front of everyone in the royal court

and dismissed him. Acharya Chanakya untied his hair tuft and took a terrible vow, "I will tie my hair again only after putting an end to the rule of Dhana Nanda, who is steeped in sensual pleasures." Kautilya (Chanakya) cursed the king and vowed to destroy his kingdom [2].



In numerous contemporary representations of Chanakya, the untied hair tuft is prominently featured as a distinctive symbol associated with his character.

Chanakya escaped from the royal army that followed him by disguising himself. He also started contemplating the means to dethrone the Nanda king and bring a diligent individual to the throne. Hence, he started looking for people endowed with qualities needed for ruling the kingdom and in time met a boy named Chandragupta who was imbued with a strong sense of Dharma. The boy and his friends were enacting a scene from the royal court. Playing the role of king, Chandragupta commendably pointed out the injustices and emphasised the importance of implementing dharmic policies to address them. Impressed by this, Chanakya adopted Chandragupta, promising to make him a real king. Kautilya took the boy to the

university in Takshashila and provided him with an education in science, arts, and military strategies [3]. Over time, the teacher used the flames of dharmic consciousness in the student to ignite a raging firestorm that eventually knocked down the Nanda dynasty.

After learning the arts of warfare and governance, they formed an army of robust and intelligent young men. Though initial attempts at overthrowing Dhana Nanda failed, as a result of tireless efforts and Chanakya's brilliant strategies, Chandragupta eventually overthrew the king and took over the throne of Magadha. During the rest of his reign, both the disciple and the Master worked tirelessly to expand the empire and unify different kingdoms of the land. As a result of their concerted efforts, Chandragupta's empire spanned the whole of India except for a small strip of land in the South. Thus, the Mauryan Empire, the greatest empire that India had ever seen, was established.



Figure 1: Mauryan Empire (323-198 BCE) extent under Ashoka (273-232 BCE)[4]



Pliny, learning of the massive empire from Megasthenes (the ambassador from Seleucus to Chandragupta), wrote that Chandragupta's army comprised 600,000 infantry, 30,000 cavalry, 8000 chariots, and 9000 elephants[5]

Chanakya's Writings: Foundations of Strategy and Governance

It must have been around this time that Chanakya wrote two seminal texts, Artha Shastra (economics) and Chanakya Neeti (aphorisms on policy/ethics/strategy). To solidify the state and ensure its beneficent continuation, Arthashastra was composed to guide a wise king, enabling him to defeat his enemies and rule correctly on behalf of the general good [6].

Arthashastra

Arthashastra explains the relevance of Artha (wealth), one of the four Purusharthas (goals of life), viz. Artha, Kama (fulfilment of desires), Dharma and Moksha (spiritual liberation). Kautilya in Arthashastra enumerates the importance of maintaining the right balance between the welfare of the people and augmenting the resources of the state [7]. Arthashastra comprises fifteen adhikaranas or books with 6000 verses. The book systematically considers issues on national security, bilateral relations, war strategies, taxation and other matters with which we are familiar today.

Even two millennia after its composition, the ideas and vision articulated by Chanakya remain profoundly relevant, invoking

deep contemplation in the minds of readers. For instance, his concept of an ideal king: A king's primary duty was towards his people, ensuring their protection during natural calamities and safeguarding them from both internal and external threats.

- The king had a threefold obligation in this regard: protection, administration, and welfare [8].
- An ideal king is one who has the highest qualities of leadership, intellectual energy, and personal character. So Kautilya advises the king to achieve the highest levels of self control, through a foundation of knowledge and discipline instilled by giving up lust, anger, greed, conceit, arrogance, and foolhardiness. He recommends the king should avoid over-indulgence in all pleasures of life [9].
- The king must be energetic and devote twelve hours a day to state affairs, which include defence, secret consultations, intelligence, public audience, and administration [10].
- A king's life should be fully dedicated to the welfare of his subjects. In the happiness of his subjects lies his happiness; in their welfare his welfare. He shall not consider as good only that which pleases him, but treat as beneficial to him whatever pleases his subjects[10].

Kautilyan Model of a State

Kautilya's theory of the state describes seven constituent elements known as 'Sapta Prakriti': the political leadership, the governing body, the people, the infrastructure, the economy, the army, and the ally (external constituent). The ability of a state to advance its interests in relation to other

states is contingent upon how closely its constituent elements align with the ideal.

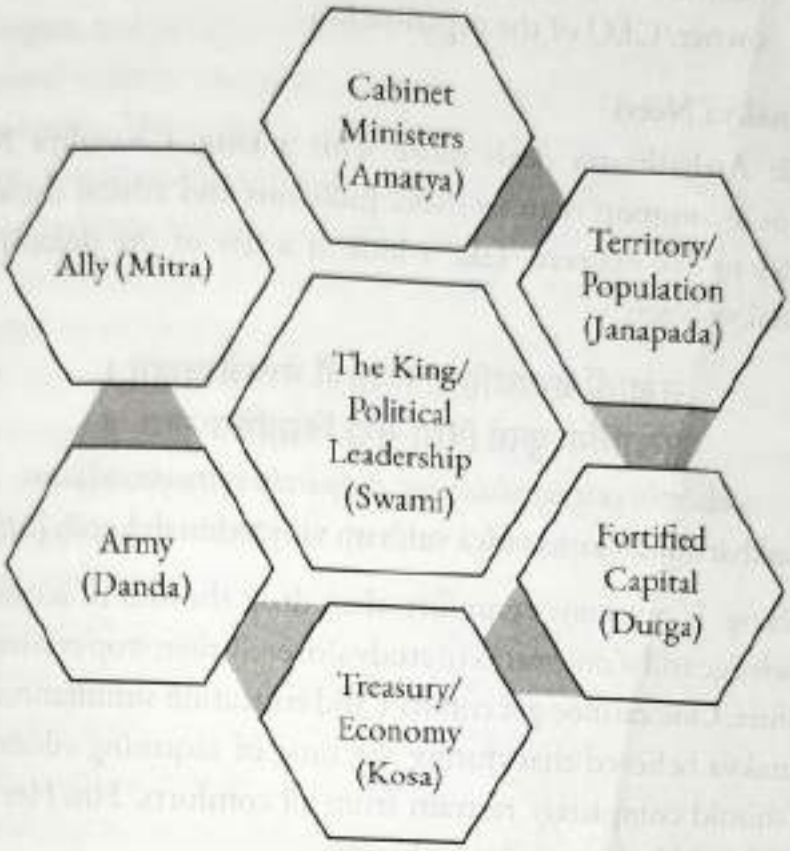


Figure 2: Seven Elements of a Kautilyan State (Sapta Prakritis)

A good understanding of public administration can be gained through the Sapta Prakriti (Seven Elements Model) proposed by Chanakya. First of which is the political leader or king in those times referred to as 'Swami'. 'Amatya' is the group of ministers who provide counselling and administrative support. 'Janapada' or territory is the area of land and people who are administered. In those days, the fort (Durga) was an important factor in wars. Kosa is the treasury. Danda is the army and Mitra form the allies.

Activity: Drawing a parallel to the Kautilyan Model of State, prepare a poster model of a present day business enterprise. Equate the Swami (king) to the owner/CEO of the organisation.

Chanakya Neeti

While Arthashastra deals more with a king, Chanakya Neeti equips a common man to make judicious and ethical decisions on day-to-day matters. Take a look at a few of the slokas from Chanakya Neeti.

सुखार्थी चेत्त्यजेद्विद्यां विद्यार्थी चेत्त्यजेत्सुखम् ।
सुखार्थिनः कुतो विद्या सुखं विद्यार्थिनः कुतः ॥

sukhārthī cettyajedvidyāṃ vidyārthī cettyajetsukham
sukhārthinaḥ kuto vidyā sukhaṃ vidyārthinaḥ kutaḥ [11]

Meaning: If one craves comfort, then drop the idea of acquiring knowledge and if one wants to study sincerely then stop craving for comfort. One cannot get comfort and education simultaneously. Chanakya believed that during the time of acquiring education one should completely restrain from all comforts. His/Her sole focus should be knowledge gathering.

जलबिन्दनिपातेन क्रमशः पूर्यते घटः।
स हेतुः सर्वविद्यानां धर्मस्य च धनस्य च॥

jala-bindu-nipātena kramaśaḥ pūryate ghaṭaḥ
sa hetuḥ sarva-vidyānāṃ dharmasya ca dhanasya ca [12]

Meaning: A pot gets filled (eventually) by drop by drop of water. So does knowledge, Dharma and wealth. This verse highlights the tireless and persistent effort required to acquire knowledge, merits, and wealth.

Conclusion

Chanakya's legacy as a scholar, strategist, and statesman transcends time, offering invaluable lessons on governance, strategies, and personal conduct. His unwavering commitment to national welfare over personal gain exemplifies the qualities of a true leader. Through his works the Arthashastra and Chanakya Neeti, he not only laid the foundations for effective statecraft but also provided wisdom applicable to everyday life. As we navigate the complexities of modern society, Chanakya's teachings remind us of the importance of self-discipline, strategic thinking, and the pursuit of knowledge. Embracing these principles can empower individuals and leaders alike to build a more just and prosperous society. Ultimately, the essence of Chanakya's philosophy encourages us to act with integrity and purpose, ensuring that we contribute positively to the world around us. One should never think that the story of Chanakya was about a shrewd person who avenged an insult from a king. King, insult, tuft and vow — all these were just expedients. Chanakya's story is about an extraordinary genius who fulfilled the national dream of uniting numerous kingdoms sharing the same culture to create an undivided and developed India based on Dharma. He was an Architect of Greater India.

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Chapter 4

BHAGAVADGĪTA: SOLDIER TO SAṂSĀRIN TO SĀDAKA

SWAMI DHYANAMRITANANDA PURI

When we hear the name Bhagavadgīta, we think that Gīta is for Sādhus and Samnyāsins. If you study Gīta, you will become a Samnyāsin. But did you know this - Arjuna was planning to leave his duty and wanted to take up samnyās. Śrī Kṛṣṇā says, "No!", and tells Arjuna that he is not fit for it now and instructs him on how to lead a purposeful life. That is Bhagavadgīta.

But for some others, the thought that comes to mind is, "Gīta is in Sanskrit" or "It is just a textbook, a book of ancient or Vedic information". The truth is that Gīta is a book of transformation.

If you understand Bhagavadgīta, you will realise that it's not something you learn by-heart and recite every day. But it is something you need to embrace, you need to live in it. It's a philosophy, a formula for life, to be lived by every human being. When you understand and apply this manual of life, you can be more peaceful, happy & content.

Arjuna was always successful and never failed in his life - hence one of his names was Vijayā. He had previously defeated Kauravas before the Mahābhāratā war, all by himself; even fought with Lord Śivā and got the Pāśupatāstrā. We all know Arjuna, Madhyama Pāṇḍavā, was the best among the 5 - in brilliance, smartness, ability, inquisitiveness, courage and he thought he always followed Dharma; that was his character. At the same time, he didn't know exactly what Dharma meant.

On the battlefield, we can see that he is doubtful, confused and in tears, yet he talks philosophy!! That's what we see in the first chapter of the Bhagavadgīta. The successful soldier succumbs to the pressure of the situation and is not able to handle it and collapses crying. Can you believe it? If this can happen to such a man of achievements, what about us?

Arjuna was thinking about what is the right thing to do? Should I get out of this war? Why create disharmony by waging war? He started speaking about the devastating consequences of the war on family and culture and plunged into a deep depression. He even goes to the extent of thinking of committing suicide by allowing his opponents to come and kill him!!

Imagine you are the army general of India and is at the frontiers during a war against a neighboring nation. At the outset of war, you decide to quit since you think war would lead to violence. What consequences will your decision have on the fate of your nation and on the people who have invested faith in you? What was the right thing to do? Do such things actually happen in the army? How will a country make sure that such things don't happen?

In case of Arjuna, suddenly, the sturdy soldier becomes a suffering saṃsārin without anything happening on the outside. Saṃsārin means

one who is desperate, despondent, dejected, depressed in the midst of all the wealth and prosperity because of one's erroneous thinking.

You see, Arjuna is just like us, with a lot of potential, but a Saṃsārin. Doesn't know what is the next best step in life - just like us. Fortunately, Arjuna realises that there is something wrong with his thinking because his best friend is silent throughout his "lecture".

If you have observed patients with mental illness, they will never agree that they have an issue. They always say that the problem is with someone else - wife, husband, boss, children, neighbours etc. It is very difficult to convince them to take medicine.

According to the National Mental Health Survey of India 2015–2016, every sixth Indian needs help with mental health. Urban areas are the most affected. As per the Japanese National Police Agency, there were 2,153 suicide deaths against 1,765 corona deaths in October 2020. So today Japan has appointed a 'Minister of Loneliness' after seeing suicide rates in the country has been increased for the first time in 11 years. The United Kingdom was the first country to appoint a loneliness minister in 2018 after they found that more than nine million people felt lonely.

All of us live through the first chapter of the Gīta in our lives, Vishada Yoga - sorrow and then depression. Unfortunately, we don't go to the second chapter, Sāṅkhya yoga, the knowledge. Therefore, we are unable to convert our sorrow and our experiences into a ladder or a stepping-stone for our progress or success.

However, the case was different with Arjuna. Arjuna was quick to realise his mistake. It may be because of his upbringing, his character or because he was learned. He doesn't know what to do and is feeling helpless and seeks help. Without any inhibition or shame, he

asks for guidance unconditionally. He says I am ready to learn, please help me. This in itself is a great realisation. And lo! Śrī Kṛṣṇā accepts.

That's when the Saṃsāriñ Arjuna transforms into a truth Seeking Sādhaka.

Kṛṣṇā tore apart Arjuna's arguments, teased him, praised him, motivated him, clarified his innermost conflicts, guaranteed to stand by him and support him, and offered help. In the end, Śrī Kṛṣṇā leaves it for Arjuna to choose for himself. A great lesson in love & friendship, rooted in freedom. Take a look at the 63rd sloka of the last chapter of Bhagavad Gita

इति ते ज्ञानमाख्यातं गुह्याद्गुह्यतरं मया।
विमृश्यैतदशेषेण यथेच्छसि तथा कुरु॥

iti te jñānam ākhyātam guhyād guhyataram mayā |
vimṛiśhyaitad aśheṣheṇa yathechchhasi tathā kuru ||

Thus, I have explained to you this knowledge
that is more secret than all secrets.
Ponder over it deeply, and then do as you wish.

Bhagavad Gita 18.63

Can you believe it? After the entire discourse Krishna asks him to deliberate deeply on the topics and do as you wish!!! This is another important facet of Indian culture where teachings are not thrusted upon you. You always have the freewill to think deeply, rationally and make a decision.

Arjuna was Droṇā's favourite student. Droṇā gave all the necessary skills to him Yet, when Arjuna was about to fail in battle, Śrī Kṛṣṇā gave him the will power to overcome his mental challenges. Droṇā trained Arjuna in military art. But training the mind to be in equilibrium at all times, is a mental art, was taught by Śrī Kṛṣṇā on the battlefield.

From Droṇā he gained all the aptitudes - learned all sorts of techniques, shooting with the right hand, the left hand and even blindfold and he would always hit the target without fail. But Śrī Kṛṣṇā taught him attitude - the right attitude towards action which takes you to the heights and keeps you at that altitude. Droṇā represents the current education system, education for living and Śrī Kṛṣṇā represents education for life. Both are necessary. This holistic view of education is what our tradition prescribes. This is Amma's way.

Arjuna was worried and confused, between his professional duty and personal duty. Kṛṣṇā reminded him performing one's own duty is better than doing someone else's duty.

As an owner of the body-mind-intellect unit, Arjuna has a primary constitutional duty which is to realise the Changeless Self. Additionally, Arjuna also has to perform the occupational duty, in the role of a soldier.

Śrī Kṛṣṇā instructs Arjuna on the importance of knowledge and action in life. Combining both, on the battlefield, he instructed Arjuna on why one should act, what to do, how to act, when should one act, where should one act, what all actions are to be performed.

Arjuna understood the power of meditation over muscle power. He was given a vision of life and the real goal of life - Knowing Brahman; which is the only way to remain peaceful, happy and secured.

Arjuna became interested and the discussion went on for a long time.

There was no subject that they did not discuss - life, death, life after death; the laws of Karma and its network; creation

sustenance and destruction of this universe; time cycles; physical, metaphysical; worldly, otherworldly; cooperation and co-existence; human rights and equality, role models and their influence in the society; dietary prescriptions and beauty techniques; environmental protection & preservation; self-development methods and skills; counselling and carrier guidance; distress management methods; dangers of lynching and gossiping; management techniques for anger and desire; the best way of dealing with inner enemies - the art of war; sūtras on real love; methods for self-purification; mind control and meditation tips, finding happiness within, ways to achieve real freedom; God realization and the life after, the life of a Sthitaprajña (Mahatma)... and so on.

Gradually Arjuna came out of his confusion and sorrow. Arjuna was convinced of his duty. He got his self-confidence back and became active, dynamic & cheerful again. He fought and won the war.

So, the muscular military man, Soldier, became a suffering Saṃsāriñ and then transformed into a seeker, a Sādaka, of truth in the presence of a great master, Śrī Kṛṣṇā. This shows the importance of a Sadguru in one's life, only a Sadguru can save us from confusions and crisis.

When Arjuna first came to the battlefield he felt pity for others. But it was misplaced compassion born out of attachment. Because of that, he refused to fight. Then he goes on to argue why he can't fight... meaning follow his Dharma, his duty.

- Why should I lead a life like this?
- What is the purpose of life?
- What is ultimate happiness and how will I attain that?

All these questions popped up in his mind. Later on, he understood his faults and felt compassion for himself. When Arjuna was ready to take responsibility for his life, he transformed himself. Śrī Kṛṣṇā acted as a catalyst.

We need to start with compassion for ourselves looking at the kind of life we lead currently. Understand what kind of life and ideals we want, look within, introspect and improve ourselves. That is compassion for oneself. Only then can we become spiritual.

When the real compassion, born out of discernment, starts to blossom in you, then you will have compassion towards the world. Then compassion becomes your nature.

As Amma always says, "The beginning and end of spirituality is in compassion."

Arjuna felt no desire, he didn't want the kingdom or even the kingship of the heavens. What is the point in acquiring all luxuries in life? You will only weaken yourselves by indulging the senses. You will not be happy. So I don't want any of them. Arjuna had a very strong dispassion.

Amma says, "These two qualities, compassion and dispassion made Arjuna a fit recipient of the knowledge of Gīta."

If you are ready to fight the battle of life, with the guidance of higher consciousness, the power of discernment, then victory shall be yours; there is no doubt in it. This is one of the messages Bhagavadgīta gives us.

Amma says, "Learning Gīta is to become Śrī Kṛṣṇā."

May you all get interested and dive deep to imbibe Bhagavadgīta and live a life with a smile throughout.

Chapter 5

LESSONS IN YOGA FROM BHAGAVADGITA

BR. ACHYUTAMRITA CHAITANYA, PH.D.

We purchase guides for certain subjects to study and improve our knowledge. But do we really purchase a guide for our growth? If such a guide exists, we would buy it and hold onto it forever. The timeless Bhagavad Gita can serve as a guide in all aspects of life. It is considered to be the most significant scripture of Sanatana Dharma and also contains the essence of all Upanishadic teachings. Bhagavan Krishna delivers this supreme knowledge to Arjuna on the battlefield of Kurukshetra through a discussion. The teachings offer wisdom on how to live a righteous, meaningful and accomplished life. It also emphasises taking decisive action, being selfless, and living a life of quality.

What is Yoga?

The word yoga comes from the Sanskrit root word "yuj," which means to unite, connect, or balance. And it connects an individual to the supreme being. In Bhagavad Gita 2.48, Bhagavan Krishna defines

yoga as "Samatvam Yogam Uchyate", which means, "Yoga is said to be a state of balance or equanimity". We misconceive Yoga as just some series of postures. It is in fact a profound concept that reveals the need for equanimity in all aspects of our lives. In the following sections, we will explore the four yogas described in the Bhagavad Gita.

Karma Yoga

Karma Yoga is the yoga of action. One of the most fundamental teachings of the Bhagavad Gita is found in the chapter on Karma Yoga. Bhagavan Sri Krishna reveals here directly,

कर्मण्येवाधिकारस्ते मा फलेषु कदाचन।
मा कर्मफलहेतुर्भूर्मा ते सङ्गोऽस्त्वकर्मणि॥

Karmaṇyēvādhikārastē mā phalēṣu kadācana |
Mā karmaphalahēturbhūr mātē saṅgō'stvakarmaṇi ||

You have a right to perform your duties,
but you are not entitled to the fruits of your actions.
Let not the fruits of action be your motive,
and never be attached to not doing your duty.

Bhagavad Gita 2.47

Here Bhagavan says that our only authority is to perform deeds, and that its outcomes may not be what we come to expect. Hence, the fruits of our actions should not be our motive for action. Isn't this confusing? If you can't expect the results, how will you study or do anything at all? But it's not like that! You have to do your duty and aim for higher marks, but you should always keep in mind that the results are not entirely in your hands. The results do depend on the effort you put in, but it is not the sole factor.

For example, we work hard for an interview and perform very well. While our performance in the interview plays a vital role, there are

factors that lie with the interviewer and the firm that determine the outcome. The firm may suddenly decide to not hire anyone at all. Or they may prefer another person who performed less but is a native of the place of work. The interviewer's mood, hidden biases, or nepotistic intentions can also affect the result. Amma usually cites the example of driving on the road. Even if we are driving carefully, a reckless driver can come and hit our vehicle.

So when Bhagavan reminds us that results are not entirely in our hands, we learn to embrace the results, even in the face of bitter failures and thus maintain a state of equanimity of mind. We can steer clear of unnecessary self blame, and our persistence will not be injured.

Now one may think, "If the outcome is not in my hands, then why put in effort at all". This is where the second part of the sloka sheds light on. We are particularly reminded to never be lazy and actionless. Our effort is indeed needed to produce results. We still have to perform to the best of our abilities. When the outcome may not be in our favour despite our best efforts, what outcome can we expect if no effort is made at all.

Bhagavan recommends that when we work let our heart be in the work and not in the result. This will ensure that results will not affect us, our drive and motivation. In short, with proper understanding, we become more action oriented trying to perfect it rather than result oriented. Invariably the results would automatically follow.

We learnt that Yoga is a state of balance or equanimity. So what then is Karma Yoga, or Yoga of action. It is detaching ourselves from the expectation of results and working hard towards perfection of action. What is balanced here? Our state of mind

is balanced, in that it doesn't fall into depression owing to adverse results. Our Karma hence becomes Karma Yoga.

Dhyana Yoga

Dhyana Yoga is the yoga of meditation. It's not just the traditional practices of sitting quietly; but it goes far beyond that. Our mind often gets the best of us, and we end up regretting things, thinking about how we could have performed or behaved better. Sometimes all that was needed would have been our patient listening or calm behaviour. And other times, we should have presented a strong, intimidating front. There may be times when we need to summon anger and times when we need control. Sometimes unmanageable irritation or anger inside us leads us to show contempt instead of respect or frown instead of smile. Or uncontrollable fear extinguishes our anger, and we cower or submit when we should intimidate.

Is it possible to train ourselves in certain ways, to be capable of commanding our mind and our senses? If such a training was there, like all heroes, we, too, can be intimidating, admirable, patient, loving, or pleasant in the right place at the right time. Is there something we can practise every day to attain exactly that? Once upon a time, a great man asked this to Bhagavan himself,

चञ्चलं हि मन: कृष्ण प्रमाथि बलवद्दृढम् ।
तस्याहं निग्रहं मन्ये वायोरिव सुदुष्करम् ।।

Cañcalaṁ hi mana: kṛṣṇa pramāthi balavaddṛḍham |
Tasyāhaṁ nigrahaṁ manyē vāyōriva suduṣkaram ||

Verily, the mind, O Kṛṣṇa, is restless, turbulent,
strong, and unyielding; I regard it quite as hard
to achieve its control as that of the wind.

Bhagavad Gita 6.34

Bhagavan replied thus,

असंशयं महाबाहो मनो दुर्निग्रहं चलं।
अभ्यासेन तु कौन्तेय वैराग्येण च गृह्यते।।

Asaṁśayaṁ mahābāhō manō durnigrahaṁ calaṁ |
Abhyāsēna tu kauntēya vairāgyēṇa ca gṛhyatē ||

Without doubt, O mighty-armed one, the mind is restless, and difficult to control; but through practice and renunciation, O son of Kuntī, the mind may be governed.

Bhagavad Gita 6.35

Bhagavan Krishna assures Arjuna, and through Arjuna to all of us, that it is possible through constant practice. But what do we practise?

When Arjuna exclaims disheartedly that it is very difficult to control the mind, Bhagavan acknowledges it and gives a very specific solution. To develop the muscles of the mind by constant practice. Many miss the common sense that Bhagavan Sri Krishna invites us to see. Just like a weak body can become strong by constant practice (of physical exercise and training), the mind too can be made strong by training and practice. What is often missed is clarity regarding what constitutes the strength of the mind, and what training gives that strength.

The strength of mind is the strength that allows us to be in control of the mind, rather than the mind being in control of us. Though we constantly refer to this strength using terms like 'will power' or 'self control' we miss that the need for such strength is as fundamental as the need for a healthy and fit body. The irony is that many of us talk about will power when we try to go to the gym to make our body strong. Most of us fail to persevere here simply because the mind is not strong enough. Having failed,

the need for mental strength escapes our attention, we blame ourselves, and move on.

Here is where Bhagavan Krishna's advice makes practical sense. Having realised the lack of mental strength we should then try to build the muscles of our mind. Bhagavan says,

सुहृन्मित्रार्युदासीनमध्यस्थद्वेष्यबन्धुषु ।
साधुष्वपि च पापेषु समबुद्धिर्विशिष्यते ।।

Suhṛnmitrāryudāsīnamadhyasthadvēṣyabandhuṣu |
Sādhuṣvapi ca pāpēṣu samabuddhirviśiṣyatē ||

He attains excellence who looks with equal regard upon well-wishers, friends, foes, neutrals, arbiters, the hateful, the relatives, and upon the righteous and the unrighteous alike.

Bhagavad Gita 6.9

Here we are asked to "look with equal regard upon well-wishers, friends, foes, neutrals, arbiters, the hateful, the relatives, and upon the righteous and the unrighteous alike." This doesn't mean that we have to turn into robots, be unexpressive, and treat friends and enemies alike. What Sri Krishna asks of us here is something specific.

When someone praises us, our mind rises in joy and we are happy. When someone blames us our mind falls into sorrow, and we are sad. When seeing a friend our mind rises to comfort and we are happy, and when with an enemy the mind lowers to discomfort and we are unhappy. In all these cases the mind does what it wants and we simply tag along. Sri Krishna is asking us to catch the mind here, in this level itself, and practice control. Try to maintain the mind in balance, not allowing it to rise and fall on its own. Be in command. We decide when the mind will rise to happiness or fall to sorrow. We decide when to be angry and intimidating.

Sri Krishna says that such strength of mind can be achieved by our conscious practice in our daily living. Alongside this He further recommends exercises (internal) for daily practice, to be done on our own, in solitude.

योगी युञ्जीत सततमात्मानं रहसि स्थित: ।
एकाकी यतचित्तात्मा निराशीरपरिग्रह: ।।

Yōgī yuñjīta satatamātmānaṁ rahasi sthita: |
Ēkākī yatacittātmā nirāśīraparigraha: ||

The Yogī should constantly practise concentration of the heart, retiring into solitude, alone, with the mind and body subdued, and free from hope and possession.

Bhagavad Gita 6.10

शुचौ देशे प्रतिष्ठाप्य स्थिरमासनमात्मन: ।
नात्युच्छ्रितं नातिनीचं चैलाजिनकुशोत्तरम् ।।

Śucau dēśē pratiṣṭhāpya sthiramāsanamātmana: |
Nātyucchritaṁ nātinīcaṁ cailājinakuśōttaram ||

Having established in a clean spot his seat, firm, neither too high nor too low, made of a cloth, a skin, and Kuśa-grass, arranged in consecution.

Bhagavad Gita 6.11

तत्रैकाग्रं मन: कृत्वा यतचित्तेन्द्रियक्रिय: ।
उपविश्यासने युञ्ज्याद्योगमात्मविशुद्धये ।।

Tatraikāgraṁ mana: kṛtvā yatacittēndriyakriya: |
Upaviśyāsanē yuñjyādyōgamātmaviśuddhayē ||

There, seated on that seat, making the mind one-pointed and subduing the action of the mind and the senses, let him practice Yoga for the purification of the heart.

Bhagavad Gita 6.12

Bhagavan Krishna thus taught Arjuna, and through him all of us too, the real nature of the mind. He further reveals how all of us can train ourselves and attain strength of mind.

Thus while Karma Yoga is equanimity in our Karma, unaffected by results, Dhyana Yoga is equanimity of the mind, unaffected by the world that happens around us.

Jnana Yoga

There was a cat once sitting very calmly next to a ferocious dog. His calmness seemed strange. Did he not care for his life? Was he lost in some fantasy of fresh fish or cosy sleep? A lavish bath of belly scratching? Was he awake at all? The dog that this cat was facing was mean. Mean enough to scare a strong grown man. He was growling in a low, dangerous tone, a warning to run away. A warning that races any heart, or scares anything with a heart.

But the cat was surprisingly calm! Was this a divine cat? A powerful being in the form of a cat? A cat that attained liberation, losing all worldly care, including his own life? Did he think that his time had come? His calmness even made the dog wonder. "Am I not scary enough? Did I miss something? Am I dressed like a clown? Does he not know how strong I am?" The dog did not think anymore; it was time to prove, "The calmness of this cat needs to be taught a lesson. Never again will he show his face in my shadow."

With a terrifying growl, the dog attacked the cat of calm, only to be stopped short, a whisper away. The dog tried hard to pull at his leash. Yet he could only manage to get the tip of his groomed nails, to reach but a hair's breadth away from the tip of the cat's nose. The cat of calm was indeed a being of power—the power of knowledge.

Why was the cat so calm? Knowledge brings Power. The cat knew that the dog was tied to a leash, and hence it wasn't scared at all. It remained very calm. Similarly, the knowledge that we are not our body, mind or intellect but the all-pervasive divinity instils eternal and infinite 'fearlessness' in us. This knowledge of self is Jnana Yoga, or the Yoga of self-knowledge.

Once upon a time, there was a Guru and Shishya living and learning in a Gurukula, near a forest. Unlike the other students, this student had trouble grasping the concepts taught by the Guru. The Guru was trying to teach him the power of knowledge and how it helps us see everything for itself. And from there, the Guru wanted to teach the student the nature of ultimate truth and the world we live in. But no matter how much the Guru discussed with him, in multiple ways and angles of approach, the shishya was unable to grasp the concept.

One day, the Guru took a walk into the forest with the Shishya. As they walked on, the student's eyes suddenly fell upon an enormous form in the shadow of a huge tree. It was an elephant. Fear flooded him, and without a second thought, he turned and ran as fast as he could. But soon he realised that he had left behind his Guru to fend for Himself. He came rushing back while trying to make sure that the elephant did not detect him. He saw his dear Guru standing very close to it. His heartbeat grew faster, he tensed, and he worried. He tried to catch the attention of his Guru from a distance and tried to gesture, asking him to make his way towards him and away from the animal. The close proximity of the elephant to the Guru terrified him. He was scared of the elephant, and now he was scared of losing his Guru to it.

Suddenly, he saw his Guru raising His hand. Then, to his utter shock, the Guru placed His hand gently on the tusk of the

elephant. And now the Guru, with his hand on the tusk, was gesturing to him to come near. Carefully, slowly, and sceptically, he walked to the Guru. His body shook as he neared the animal; the only confidence he had was in his Guru. Now the Guru asked him to look up at the elephant and touch its tusk. The student managed to do it and placed his hand next to his Guru's. His fear vanished in an instant. The elephant was, in fact, made of wood. The Guru then said,

Marattai maṟaittatu māmata yāṉai
Marattil maṟaintatu māmata yāṉai
Parattai maṟaittaṉa pārmutal pūtam
Parattil maṟaintaṉa pārmutal pūtamē

That which hid the wood was the elephant.
That which disappeared in the wood was the elephant.
That which hides in creation is the creator.
That which disappears in creation is the creator.
Tirumantiram of Tirumūlar

The Guru thus, with a practical method, imparted the most profound wisdom to the student.

The Guru decided to teach this student using a practical method, since all other methods seemed ineffective. He arranged, with the help of his other students, a wooden elephant to be made in the size of an actual elephant. It was then placed in a particular place in the forest.

The message of this story is that when you see the elephant, the wood is hidden, and when you see the wood, the elephant vanishes. Similarly, the knowledge of self makes everything vanish, while when you see everything else, you miss the real

self. Amma gives a similar example. When we go to a jewellery store, we see earrings, bangles, chains, nose rings, lockets, etc. We see the ornaments as one different from the other. And when we see them as gold, the differences disappear. Of course for all practical purposes they are different ornaments. But the reality is that they are the same, in that they are all gold. Similarly we all appear to be different from each other, our friends, family, the trees, the animals, the birds, etc. And for all practical purposes of daily living we feel different. But the underlying reality, just like in the case of gold ornaments and gold, is that we are all one with the real self, the Paramatma. Bhagavan Sri Krishna reveals,

नासतो विद्यते भावो नाभावो विद्यते सतः।
उभयोरपि दृष्टोऽन्तस्त्वनयोस्तत्त्वदर्शिभिः ॥

Nāsatō vidyatē bhāvō nābhāvō vidyatē sataḥ |
Ubhayōrapi dṛṣṭō'ntastvanayōstattvadarśibhiḥ ||

The unreal never is. The Real never is not.
Those possessed of the knowledge of the
Truth fully know both these.

Bhagavad Gita 2.16

In Gita, the path of self-knowledge is prescribed very extensively. There is no need for us to become something other than our real nature. It is neither possible to add anything to our self nor to take anything away from it. The only thing that we can do is remove the veils covering the self. If we constantly strive to remain in our natural state, the self will shine on its own, removing the veil.

This is Jnana Yoga, where we learn to discern between that which is real and that which is not. We are enabled to see the

world clearly, without bias, and to respond to situations with compassion and wisdom rather than reactivity and emotional turmoil. We remain balanced in what is real, without allowing the unreal to affect us.

Bhakti Yoga

India has a long tradition of Bhakti, or, in other words, devotion. The length and breadth of this land reverberate with stories of devotion and how devotion leads one person to Moksha, or, in other words, liberation. In every state of this country, you would find Mahatmas and sages who were devotees of different Iswaras and taught about devotion. For Shiva devotees, there are sages known as Nayanar Saints, Conclusionwho are 63 in number. There are Alwars who are Vishnu devotees, Sri Rama Bhaktha devotees like Tulsi Das, Krishna devotees like Mira Bai, and thousands of others. Each of their stories is also inspiring and instils devotion in the listeners.

Pusalar Nayanar of the eighth century is identified as one of the 63 Nayanars. He was a devotee of Bhagavan Siva living in Thiruninravur, Tamil Nadu. We can read about him in the Periyapuranam compiled and written by Sekkizhar in the 12th century. Pusalar considered mental worship thousands of times better than external ritualistic worship. At the same time, he strongly desired to build a temple for Lord Shiva, but he did not have enough money for it. He was a poor person, working hard to make both ends meet. So, he started building the temple mentally every day by constantly meditating on Shiva and decided a day for the consecration.

In the meantime, the king of that place, who was also a great devotee of Lord Siva, was building a magnificent temple in

Kanjeevaram. Coincidentally, he also fixed the same auspicious date, which Pusalar had chosen, for the installation of the Lord form in his temple he built in his mind. One day, the king had a dream. Bhagavan Shiva asked him to postpone the installation ceremony at his temple because He would be visiting a temple that one of His devotees had built in Thiruninravur. The king woke up from sleep and was intensely eager to have the Darshan of the devotee mentioned by Bhagavan. The king also wondered if this temple of the devotee was more magnificent than his own temple, since Bhagavan decided to go there.

The king came to Thiruninravur with his attendants and soldiers and started searching all over the place for the temple; he could not find any. All the villagers reported that there were no Shiva temples built in that place. Then one person told the king that there was an ardent devotee of Shiva in the place by the name of Pusalar. Thinking he might be able to help locate the Shiva temple, the king found out about Pusalar's house and approached him.

Pusalar was stunned when he heard of the king's dream. Soon, he recovered and was filled with joy. He said, "How kind and compassionate is my God? I am only a normal being, and He has accepted my mental shrine as His abode. I am really blessed." He told the king that that temple was only in his mind. The king was greatly surprised to hear this. Admiring Pusalar's devotion, the king fell at his feet and worshipped him. Pusalar installed the Lord in his mental temple and continued to worship Him till he attained His Abode.

Amma once said, "The real question is not whether God exists or not, but whether human beings have sorrow or not. Bhakti,

or devotion, is the practical way of getting rid of sorrows. Bhakti is a practical science. Bhakti is not blind superstitious belief. It is this faith that removes darkness from our hearts. Not only does it help us unburden our heart, it also amplifies our sense of righteousness and inspires us to be compassionate towards the distressed. Devotion to God and compassion for the world are but two sides of the same coin. Jñana and Bhakti are not two; if Jñana is the fruit of a tree, Bhakti is the juice of that fruit."

On another occasion Amma said, "The path of bhakti teaches love. First, you develop one-pointed love towards God. When that love becomes the centre of your life and as the devotional practices become more and more intense, your vision changes. You come to understand that God dwells as pure consciousness in all beings, including you. As this experience becomes stronger and stronger, the love in you also grows until, at last, you become That. The love within you expands and embraces the entire universe with all its beings. You become the personification of love. This love removes all dryness from you. This love is the best cure for all emotional blocks and for all negative feelings."

In the Bhagavad Gita, Bhagavan Sri Krishna says,

अद्वेष्टा सर्वभूतानां मैत्रः करुण एव च।
निर्ममो निरहङ्कारः समदुःखसुखः क्षमी।।
सन्तुष्टः सततं योगी यतात्मा दृढनिश्चयः।
मय्यर्पितमनोबुद्धिर्यो मद्भक्तः स मे प्रियः।।

Advēṣṭā sarvabhūtānāṁ maitraḥ karuṇa ēva ca |
Nirmamō nirahaṅkāraḥ samaduḥkhasukhaḥ kṣamī ||
Santuṣṭaḥ satataṁ yōgī yatātmā dṛḍhaniścayaḥ |
Mayyarpitamanōbuddhiryō madbhaktaḥ sa mē priyaḥ ||

He who hates no creature, and is friendly and
compassionate towards all,
who is free from the feelings of "I and mine",
even-minded in pain and pleasure,
forbearing, ever content, steady in meditation,
self-controlled, and possessed of firm conviction,
with mind and intellect fixed on Me; he who
is thus devoted to Me, is dear to Me.

Bhagavad Gita 12.13 - 14

Bhakti Yoga is hence the highest form of Samatva or equanimity we can achieve. Developing Bhakti for our God, develops love for all beings in the universe. We develop a sense of equanimity towards all.

Conclusion

The Bhagavad Gita is like a user manual for our lives. It teaches us many important lessons, and the yogas connect us to divinity or help us realise that our divinity is the principal idea. Each spiritual seeker is called upon to decide which Yoga best fits his/her natural disposition. Karma yoga is advised for action-oriented people. While Dhyana Yoga is recommended for all, it is well suited for those who are naturally introspective, and calm inside. Bhakti Yoga is best suited for devotional people who can easily connect to God emotionally. And Jnana Yoga or the Yoga of knowledge, is for highly rational people who can use discrimination. For the benefit of oneself and others, practise and engage in yoga and reap its rewards.

Amma says, "All yogas aim at samatva bhava (attitude of equanimity). What is known as yoga is samatva. There is no God beyond that, whatever may be the path. That state should be attained."

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Chapter 2

UNVEILING THE ROOTS OF FEAR: PATHWAYS TO FEARLESSNESS

SRIKANTA PARIDA, PH.D.

The Sanskrit word "Bhaya" meaning "fear", is a fundamental human emotion often triggered by the perception of danger or threat. Fear can manifest in various ways, including physical symptoms such as sweating and increased heart rate, as well as psychological symptoms such as anxiety and panic. Some people may even freeze completely, unable to move. Fear can help keep us safe from harm, but it can also hold us back from reaching our full potential. To overcome fear, it's important to first acknowledge and accept it, rather than trying to ignore or suppress it. Once we understand the source of our fear, we can begin to take steps to face it and move beyond it. In his commentary of the Bhagavad Gita, Guḍhārtha Dīpikā, Madhusudan Sarasvati states in Chapter 2,

रागविषयस्य विनाशके समुपस्थिते
तन्निवारणासामर्थ्यमात्मनो मन्यमानस्य
दैन्यात्मकश्चित्तवृत्तिविशेषो भयम्

rāgaviṣayasya vināśake samupasthite
tannivāraṇāsāmarthyamātmano manyamānasya
dainyātmakaścittavṛttiviśeṣo bhayam

It means, "Fear is a particular state of mind characterized by a sense of helplessness, arising in a person who, when faced with the destruction of something they are attached to, believes they are incapable of preventing its loss."

It explores the psychological roots of fear, particularly in the context of attachment. It highlights how fear is closely tied to the mind's perception of vulnerability and loss. When a person becomes attached to something—whether it be wealth, relationships, social status, or material comforts—the possibility of losing it creates fear. This fear intensifies when the individual believes they lack the power or means to prevent such a loss. At the core of this fear is the assumption of personal inadequacy or helplessness. The mind anticipates future dangers or threats to something it holds dear, and the inability to control these potential losses leads to a state of mental suffering. This helplessness is what transforms an attachment into a source of fear.

> Activity 1: Write down your fears, identify what causes each one, describe its effects on you, and think of one small step to face it.

The Root Cause of Fear

Swami Vivekananda pointed out that the law of cause and effect demonstrates the interconnectedness of the entire universe. Every event, thought, feelings or action is part of a larger web of causality that influences our world. He said

"The whole universe is bound by the law of causation. There cannot be anything uncaused— every thought has a cause, every effect must have a cause, and the cause is not an effect of something else." Applying the principle of cause and effect to fear, we can understand fear as an effect with identifiable causes, and by addressing those causes, we can potentially reduce or overcome it. Fear is the result (effect) of certain thoughts, experiences, or perceptions (causes). It doesn't arise on its own but is triggered by a variety of factors, both external and internal.

① Ignorance (Avidya)

Our true self (Atman) is eternal, changeless, and beyond physical existence. However, ignorance makes us identify ourselves with the body, mind, and ego, which are temporary and subject to birth, death, and suffering. This false identification with the material world and the body leads to a fear of death, loss, and uncertainty; because we mistakenly believe that our existence is fragile and finite. In Vedanta philosophy it is said that fear arises from ignorance of our true nature. According to the Mundaka Upanishad –

भिद्यते हृदयग्रन्थिश्छिद्यन्ते सर्वसंशयाः।
क्षीयन्ते चास्य कर्माणि तस्मिन् दृष्टे परावरे।।

bhidyate hṛdayagranthiśchidyante sarvasaṃśayāḥ|
kṣīyante cāsya karmāṇi tasmindṛṣṭe parāvare||

When one realizes the Supreme, the knots of the heart are loosened, all doubts are cleared, and all karma is destroyed.

Mundaka Upanishad 2.2.8

Means ignorance (Avidya) creates the "knots of the heart," binding us in fear and delusion. Fear dissolves, only through realization of the highest truth.

The manual of human life Bhagavad Gita also says ignorance is the cause of delusion and fear. Knowledge (Jnana) removes this ignorance.

ज्ञानेन तु तदज्ञानं येषां नाशितमात्मनः।
तेषामादित्यवज्ज्ञानं प्रकाशयति तत्परम्॥

jñānena tu tad ajñānaṁ yeṣhāṁ nāśhitam ātmanaḥ |
teṣhām āditya-vaj jñānaṁ prakāśhayati tat param ||

For those whose ignorance is destroyed by knowledge, the supreme self is revealed like the sun illuminating everything.

Bhagavad Gita 5.16

② Attachment (Raga)

Attachment to worldly things, such as material possessions, relationships, status, and physical comfort, creates fear because these things are impermanent. The fear of losing them or failing to satisfy desires leads to anxiety and suffering. The more we are attached to the external world, the more vulnerable we become to fear. In the Bhagavad Gita, Sri Krishna says, *"Dhyāyato viṣayān puṁsaḥ saṅgas teṣūpajāyate".* (Attachment arises, when one contemplates objects of the senses.

त्रिविधं नरकस्येदं द्वारं नाशनमात्मनः।
कामः क्रोधस्तथा लोभस्तस्मादेतत्त्रयं त्यजेत्॥

tri-vidhaṁ narakasyedaṁ dvāraṁ nāśhanam ātmanaḥ
kāmaḥ krodhas tathā lobhas tasmād etat trayaṁ tyajet

Three are the gates to this hell of self-destruction—desire, anger, and greed; therefore, one must renounce these three.

Bhagavad Gita 16.21

It means that attachment leads to desires, and unfulfilled desires lead to fear and suffering. Renouncing these desires helps free one from fear.

(3) Duality (Dvaita)

Fear arises from the perception of duality—the belief that we are separate from the world, others, and ultimately from the Divine (Brahman). This sense of separation creates insecurity and fear of the unknown, leading us to cling to things and people for a false sense of security. Once, a young shishya (student) asked his guru, "Why do I feel so afraid of losing people and things around me?" The guru smiled and took him to a riverbank. Pointing to the river, he said, "Look at the water—it flows freely, touching the plants, fish, and rocks. Yet it never tries to cling to any of them. It simply flows, knowing it's always part of the great ocean." The guru continued, "Fear comes when we believe we are separate, like a drop of water that thinks it's alone. In truth, just as every drop is part of the ocean, you are part of the Divine (Brahman), and everything around you is connected. This oneness means you're never alone; there's no need to cling. Realizing this brings true peace." The shishya understood that by letting go of his sense of separation, he could live freely, without fear, feeling deeply connected to everyone and everything.

Brihadaranyaka Upanishad says, "Fear is born of duality."[1] This directly tells us that the perception of duality is the root cause of

[1] Dvitīyādvai bhayam bhavati, Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 1.4.2

fear. Fear arises when one sees themselves as separate from others or the divine. The ultimate goal in Advaita Vedanta is to realize that there is no duality, only Oneness (Brahman). According to the Chandogya Upanishad, "All this is indeed Brahman."[2] It emphasizes that when one realizes that everything is Brahman (the ultimate reality), fear born of separation disappears.

Non-dual philosophies like Advaita Vedanta teach that fear dissolves when one realizes the oneness of all existence—that there is no separation between the individual self and the universal self (Brahman).

Karma and Samskaras

Past karma and Samskaras, or the mental impressions or tendencies from past deeds, are another source of anxiety. Fear can become firmly ingrained in the subconscious mind because of prior experiences from this life or past lives. These perceptions influence our feelings and ideas today, causing fear as a response to unresolved attachments or traumas from the past. According to Bhagavad Gita, "The ways of karma are indeed complex."[3] This implies that karma operates through an intricate and subtle law of cause and effect, where our actions and their results are not always immediately evident. Fear can manifest as a karmic consequence of past actions driven by selfish desires, violence, or harm to others. Such actions can cause anxiety about future outcomes and fear of retribution, either in this life or future lives. For example, a person who has engaged in deceitful business practices in the past may have short-term financial gains but has accumulated negative karma, leading to guilt, anxiety, and insecurity. This

[2] Sarvam khalvidam brahma, Chandogya Upanishad 7.26.2
[3] Gahanā karmano gatih, Bhagavad Gita 4.17

fear, despite not directly related to current circumstances, is a karmic consequence of past actions, causing worry about future retribution.

Samskaras refer to the subtle mental impressions left by past experiences, thoughts, and actions (karma). These impressions shape our mental patterns, habits, and tendencies (vrittis). Fear is often a manifestation of deeply ingrained samskaras, which can arise due to past trauma, conditioned beliefs, or negative experiences. For example, a person who was frequently criticized as a child may develop deep mental impressions (samskaras) of unworthiness. As an adult, this manifests as a fear of public speaking or social situations, even when there's no real threat, showing how past experiences shape current fears.

Pathways to Fearlessness

The Sanskrit word "Abhaya" means "Bhayasya Abhavah" means "Fearlessness". Fearlessness is a state of being free from worries about present or future suffering. Excessive attachment in any form generates fear. For instance, attachment to wealth brings fear of poverty; attachment to social status creates fear of disgrace, attachment to immoral behaviour leads to anxiety about its consequences, and attachment to physical comfort results in fear of illness.

True Knowledge (Sat Jnana)

'Sat' means the "Real", "Eternal", or "Truth". Sat refers to that which is real, permanent, and exists without change. In Vedanta, it is often identified with Brahman, the ultimate reality that is beyond all forms and phenomena. Sat is eternal, immutable, and the substratum of all existence. In the Bhagavad Gita, Sri Krishna says,

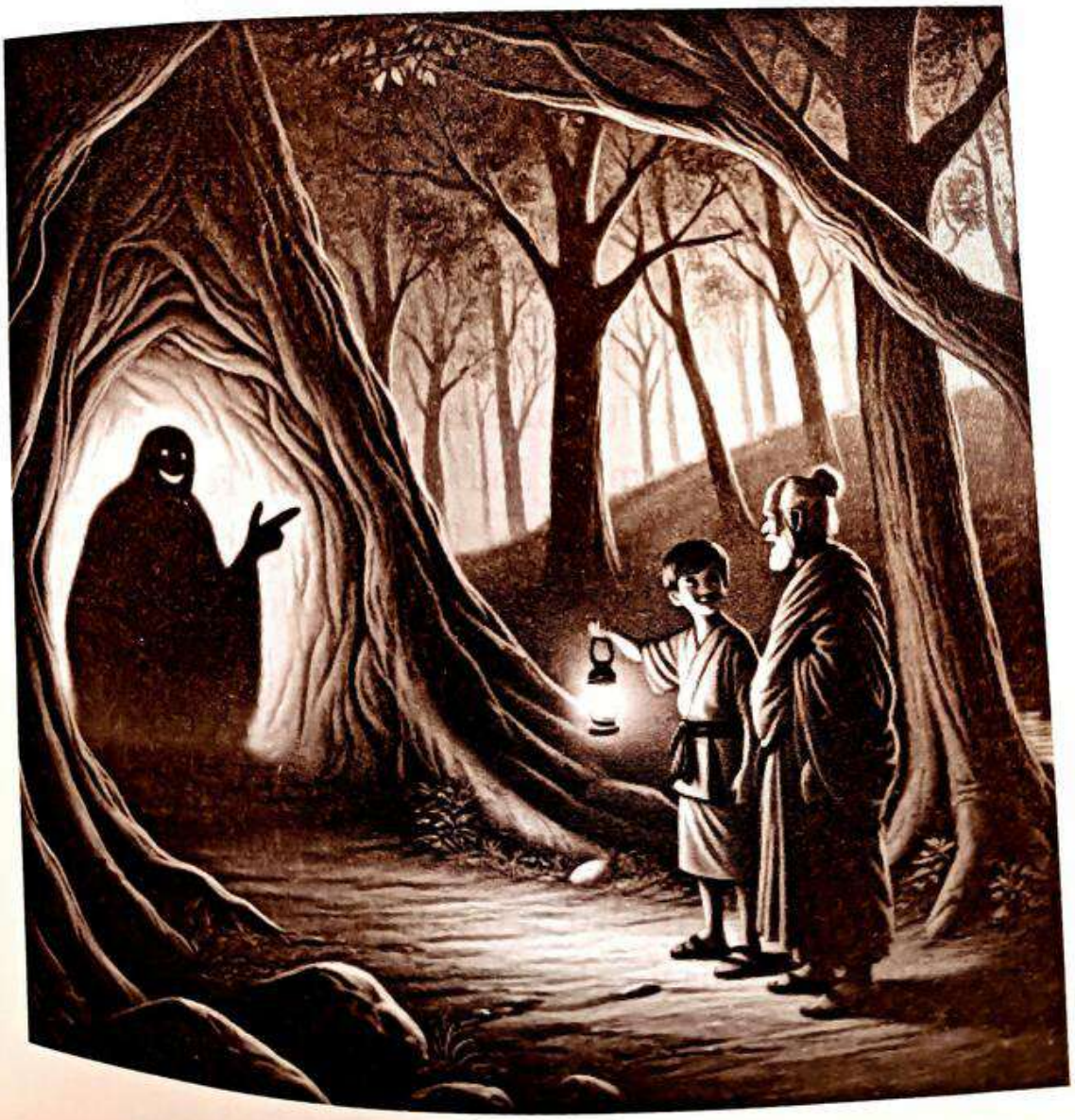
नासतो विद्यते भावो नाभावो विद्यते सतः ।
उभयोरपि दृष्टोऽन्तस्त्वनयोस्तत्त्वदर्शिभिः ॥

Nāsato vidyate bhāvo nābhāvo vidyate sataḥ |
Ubhayorapi dṛiṣhṭo 'nta stvanayos tattva-darśhibhiḥ ||

The unreal (Asat) has no existence, and the real (Sat) never ceases to be. The seers of the truth have concluded this by studying the nature of both.

Bhagavad Gita 2.16

Fear comes from our attachment to things that don't last, like our body, belongings, and life situations. These things are part of Asat (the unreal), which is temporary and constantly changing. But



our true self (Atman)—Sat (the real)—is eternal and unchanging. When we understand that our true self is beyond the physical body and mind and cannot be harmed, we can let go of our attachment to temporary things and accept life's changes. This helps us move beyond fear, knowing nothing outside can truly hurt our real self. This brings us inner peace and fearlessness.

Sat Jnana (knowledge of the real) is considered the key to overcoming fear and attaining fearlessness. Let's understand this concept through a story. Once upon a time, a curious disciple learned under a wise guru in a serene forest ashram. One evening, the guru asked the disciple to fetch water from a cave nearby. It was getting dark, and the disciple hesitated but obeyed. As the disciple entered the cave, the dim light of his lantern flickered on the walls. Suddenly, he froze in fear. On the far wall, he saw a massive, terrifying shadow that seemed to stretch and grow larger with every passing moment. The disciple's hands trembled, and his heart raced. He turned and ran out of the cave, breathless and pale.

Back at the ashram, he frantically told his guru, "There's something monstrous in the cave! It's huge and terrifying. I couldn't bring the water." The guru smiled and said gently, "Fear often grows in the darkness of the unknown. Let's go together and see what this monster is." Reluctantly, the disciple followed the guru back to the cave. As they entered, the guru calmly held up the lantern and walked closer to the shadow. When they reached the spot, the disciple's fear melted away. The terrifying shadow on the wall was just the enlarged outline of a harmless little tree branch swaying in the breeze. The guru turned to the disciple and said, "Fear often comes from our imagination and false knowledge. When we look closely, most fears shrink or disappear entirely. Remember,

the way to conquer fear is to shine the light of understanding on it." Just like the tree branch is different from the monster in the cave, similarly our true nature, the "Self", is different from "Prakriti" (the material world). By understanding that the true self is beyond the transient world, fear dissipates, and one attains fearlessness. Sat Jnana serves as the ultimate remedy for fear by revealing the unchanging reality that underlies all existence, leading to liberation and the state of Abhaya (fearlessness).

The Knowledge of the Mind

Once a person asked Amma, "When I think about the law of karma, I sometimes feel very afraid." Amma told him, "Everything that is born one day has to die. You are not the body and you are not the mind. So, why be afraid? We need to strive for dharma fearlessly. For that, you need dedication and courage. In the military, soldiers are trained in a manner that helps them transcend fear. They have to run amidst exploding bombs. They have to survive in the jungle, eating whatever they can—even snakes. This is the training that transforms them into dedicated and fearless soldiers. They are ready to undergo all this in order to become an offering to the country. Here there is also a training for fearlessness. In fact, we must become even more fearless than soldiers if we are to become an offering to the world. Understanding you are not the body, you should adhere to dharma and live without fear."

According to the Bharatiya Darshana, fear comes from misunderstandings in the mind. In Nyaya and Vaisheshika, fear arises when we are confused about the world around us. For example, a student might fear failing an exam because they are uncertain about their preparation. But by gaining clear knowledge and studying well, the fear disappears. In Sankhya,

fear happens when we mistakenly think we are only our body or material things. For example, someone might fear aging because they identify with their changing body, but realizing their true self is beyond the body helps them let go of that fear. Yoga teaches that mental disturbances cause fear, like when someone is anxious about future events. By practicing meditation, they calm their mind and feel peaceful. In Mimamsa, fear is reduced by living in harmony with eternal laws, like when people feel secure by following their values and doing what's right. Finally, in Advaita Vedanta, fear comes from thinking we are separate from everything. For example, someone may fear death because they see themselves as separate from the universe, but understanding they are one with the universe removes that fear. Understanding the mind and our true self helps dissolve fear and brings lasting peace.

Overcoming Fear through Devotion and Spiritual Practices

The beautiful story of Lord Hanuman crossing the ocean to find Sita in Lanka profoundly illustrates fearlessness in action. When Sita was taken to Lanka by Ravana, Hanuman was chosen to cross the vast ocean that separated them and bring back news of her to Lord Rama. Although the task seemed daunting, Hanuman approached it with unshakable confidence. Driven by his love and devotion to Rama, he leapt across the ocean without hesitation, embodying true fearlessness—an attitude of complete faith and absence of self-doubt. On his way, Hanuman encountered several obstacles, yet each challenge only strengthened his resolve. When Mainaka Mountain emerged from the ocean, offering him a place to rest, Hanuman graciously declined, explaining that his mission took priority over his own comfort. His focus on the goal made him fearless, undistracted by temptations. Then, the

serpent goddess Surasa appeared, attempting to block his path. Undeterred, Hanuman skillfully adapted, first expanding his size to match her challenge, then shrinking down to pass through her mouth in an instant. This showed that fearlessness is not merely brute force but the ability to think clearly, adapt, and stay undisturbed. Finally, Simhika, the demoness, attempted to drag him down by capturing his shadow, but Hanuman fearlessly confronted her, using his immense strength to defeat her.

Arriving in Lanka, Hanuman successfully found Sita and reassured her of Rama's plan to rescue her. Hanuman's fearless journey exemplifies how courage arises from selfless devotion and inner strength, not from the absence of danger. His unwavering focus on Rama and his mission allowed him to face each obstacle with calmness, clarity, and bravery, showing that true fearlessness comes from dedication to a higher purpose and the unshakeable belief that no obstacle is insurmountable.

Spiritual practices emphasize the importance of awareness in overcoming fear, through practices such as,

- Meditation (Dhyana): Helps calm the mind, reduce anxiety, and connect with one's inner self, fostering fearlessness.
- Chanting Mantras: Reciting powerful mantras like the Maha Mrityunjaya Mantra instills strength and protects against fear.
- Pranayama (Breathing Techniques): Practices like Anulom Vilom and Nadi Shodhana regulate the breath, easing physical and emotional fear.
- Seva (Selfless Service): Shifts focus from self-centered worries to helping others, reducing personal fears.

Surrendering the illusion of control is another key pathway to fearlessness, as true courage emerges when we trust in the flow of life and surrender our attachment to specific outcomes. This surrender cultivates resilience and inner strength, enabling us to gracefully navigate uncertainties. Spiritual practice will help us to nurturing love, compassion, and forgiveness acts as a powerful antidote to fear, helping us dismantle the barriers it erects and fostering deeper connections with ourselves and others. Spiritual Practice empowers us to reconnect with our true essence, and embrace life with open hearts, transforming fear into a facilitator for growth and peace.

Conclusion

Exploring fear and the pathways to fearlessness reveals profound insights rooted in ancient Indian philosophies. Fear, or "Bhaya", is deeply entangled with our attachments, ignorance, and perceptions of duality. It stems from our identification with the temporary aspects of existence—our bodies, possessions, and social status—leading to a pervasive sense of insecurity. However, by cultivating "Sat Jnana", the knowledge of the eternal and unchanging reality, individuals can transcend these fears. Philosophies such as Nyaya, Sankhya, and Advaita Vedanta offer valuable frameworks for understanding how fear arises from misunderstanding and ignorance, urging us to seek the truth of our being beyond the material world. Through spiritual practices like mindfulness and meditation, we learn to recognize our fears without judgment, transforming them into catalysts for growth. Additionally, embracing love, and compassion, and surrendering the illusion of control empowers us to face life's uncertainties with courage. Ultimately, by

Chapter 1

VISION & MISSION OF INDIAN KNOWLEDGE SYSTEMS

ARAVINDAN NEELAKANDAN

Introduction

What is the mission of Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS)? One important goal is to foster a sense of pride among Indians, especially since this pride has often been overlooked or undermined. This sense of pride is essential, as its absence can lead to various challenges. People everywhere tend to believe that their civilization is superior. While it is important to have pride grounded in faith and reason, we should also recognize the valuable contributions our civilization can make to the world. A key mission of IKS is to raise awareness among all Indians about the richness of our cultural heritage. However, it is crucial that this pride is not based on false notions. When pride is built on misconceptions, it can eventually collapse, leaving a void that may result in significant issues.

Contributing to Human Welfare and Truth

A vital goal of IKS is to make a meaningful contribution to human welfare and the pursuit of truth. You might wonder, "Can Indian knowledge systems help me become a true contributor to humanity and the search for truth?" The answer is yes, as demonstrated by the inspiring example of Dr. E C George Sudarshan. He was a physicist who drew inspiration from Indian knowledge systems and applied Vedantic principles in his work. This unique perspective shaped his approach to science, offering an innovative way to understand scientific concepts from an early age. He highlighted that government curricula and our constitution encourage the development of a scientific mindset, framing it as a duty of citizenship.

Currently, there is a tendency to define "scientific temper" based on personal ideologies, leading some to label other viewpoints as unscientific. Understanding the origins of the term is essential in this context. The term is often mistakenly attributed to Jawaharlal Nehru; however, it was coined by Bertrand Russell in a Western context. In India, this concept was adopted and integrated into the Constitution. In the West, "scientific temper" emphasises the importance of avoiding religious biases and considering multiple viewpoints, although it is still regarded as a somewhat flawed concept.

The introduction of the term "scientific temper" into the Indian Constitution during the Emergency has often been used as a political tool. When individuals want to criticise others, they may claim that opposing views lack scientific temper, suggesting a violation of constitutional principles. In essence, "scientific temper" can sometimes align with specific political agendas. Dr.

George Sudarshan proposed an alternative perspective on science deeply rooted in Indian tradition. He argued that exploring the physical universe can be viewed as a form of spiritual practice (sadhana). For instance, he referenced the Vishnu Sahasranama, where the first verse, "Viswam Vishnu," represents the universe. According to his philosophy, investigating the universe is akin to exploring the sacred body of Vishnu. This approach suggests that scientific discovery offers a non-dualistic perspective, resonating with Advaita philosophy.

The joy of discovery, which is deeply embedded in the Indian psyche, is closely tied to the pursuit of truth and ultimate bliss. This quest for truth—whether it is physical, psychological, or spiritual—guides individuals toward the realisation of Brahman, the ultimate reality. Engaging in the search for truth allows one to experience this profound reality, which serves as a fundamental motivation behind all beliefs. This principle applies to scientific exploration and extends to artistic creation, acts of service (seva), and spiritual practices (sadhana). Each of these endeavours reflects a commitment to uncovering deeper truths and connecting with the essence of existence.

The mission and vision of IKS should strive to bring happiness and welfare to all beings, in harmony with the principles of Indian civilization. This dual purpose serves to instil pride in our heritage while leveraging that heritage to promote overall well-being and bliss for everyone. At its core, the foundational mission of IKS is to enhance happiness and welfare for all existence.

Another compelling example of this is Tamil Nadu's commendable ranking in the human resource index, largely attributed to the midday meal scheme initiated by Kamaraj. Although many

ideological factions claim credit for this program, its roots can be traced back to the Travancore kingdom, where it was first introduced.

Kamaraj, a member of Parliament from Nagercoil, recognized the importance of this scheme when he learned about its impact on school attendance and student welfare. The midday meal scheme was inspired by earlier efforts, such as those by Kalavala Kannan Chetty in Colonial Madras, who provided milk to children attending school. In Travancore, C P Ramaswamy Iyyer played a pivotal role in implementing similar initiatives. The question we must ask is this, "Why were these leaders motivated to introduce such programs?"

The answer is simple. These leaders were deeply rooted in Indian culture, where we have the concept of gurukula. A key aspect of this tradition is that students should receive food through biksha, or alms, from society. When students are nourished by the community, they develop a sense of indebtedness to it. This indebtedness fosters a commitment to use their knowledge for the welfare of society.

This is why we often find exceptional scientists, such as those at ISRO, emerging from government schools. In contrast, students from private schools who receive quality education may tend to seek opportunities beyond their communities. However, students from government schools, like the esteemed Dr. A P J Abdul Kalam, frequently feel a strong sense of duty to give back to the nation, recognizing the support they have received from society.

The concept of society nourishing schoolchildren has its roots in the gurukula system. It has been effectively adapted to modern contexts by leaders like C P Ramaswamy Iyyer, Kamaraj, and

Kannan Chetty. Their implementation of these principles has led to significant improvements in literacy rates and human resource indices. While some may attribute this progress to various ideological models, it is fundamentally grounded in the Bharatiya model.

The Bharatiya model has been successfully updated and aligned with the Constitution. When we think of gurukula, we often envision a residential school focused solely on recitations. However, the true brilliance of leaders like CP Ramaswamy and Kamaraj lies in their ability to distil the essence of these traditions, adapt them for contemporary society, and apply them effectively. This intuitive civilizational vision must be instilled in students as a crucial aspect of IKS.

The next important question is: How can we achieve this, and what pathways can lead us toward this goal?

Integrating Knowledge into Education

To effectively integrate our knowledge and wisdom from the dharmasastras, puranas, itihasas and upanishads into the education of our children, we must create a system that encompasses both written and oral traditions. This approach should ensure that these teachings are applicable in their daily lives. For instance, many children in India are familiar with the story of Partha and the bird, which serves as a powerful example of intense concentration. Another popular story is that of the squirrels who helped Rama in creating the Ramasetu bridge, which motivates one to serve or volunteer for the welfare of the world. Such stories are assimilated even by people with no particular religious or spiritual inclinations.

The image of the squirrel aiding Rama in building the bridge has deeply permeated the Indian psyche, even though it is not explicitly mentioned in the Valmiki Ramayana. Rationalists might question whether Rama's touch on the squirrel should result in similar markings on all he touches, overlooking the deeper significance of the story. This reflects a tragic misunderstanding that has affected our civilization. In contrast, many other religions tend to adhere strictly to their scriptures. For instance, when scripture states that God created the world in ten days, followers often interpret this literally. However, as scientific understanding evolved, explaining that creation is a gradual process spanning billions of years, these same believers began to reinterpret their texts in a more poetic or mystical light.

In India, we have been gifted a poetic and spiritual narrative through our Puranas. Yet, there is often pressure to interpret these stories in a strictly literal manner, which is quite unfortunate. When we share the tale of the squirrel assisting in the construction of Rama's bridge, it brings joy to people because they appreciate the deeper meaning behind the Purana. This is how Puranic elements become embedded in the collective consciousness, guiding our values and influencing our approach to social work. These teachings are prevalent in our oral traditions. For instance, the first literary reference to the squirrel episode appears in Thondaradippodi Alvar's hymn, which, although outside of the Valmiki Ramayana, has gained broader recognition across India.

Such oral traditions are prevalent everywhere. Another notable example is "Marutvamala," which can be found along the route from Nagercoil to Kanyakumari. This hill remains lush and green, unlike others that have been quarried, because it is believed

that a small pebble fell from the mountain while Hanuman was carrying it, transforming into Marutvamala. This site holds special significance as it was where Narayana Guru and Ayya Vaikunta meditated. Today, more than 118 species of herbs thrive there, supporting various Vaidyar communities that rely on these plants for their livelihoods. This illustrates a local oral tradition that, while not central to mainstream traditions, aligns with the broader spirit of Indian heritage and the essence of Valmiki's teachings. The preservation of this hill reflects an eco-dharmic tradition that is often overlooked. Unfortunately, much like a fish unaware and unappreciative of the water it swims in, we often fail to recognize the importance of these traditions because we are so deeply immersed in them.

Without these cultural traditions, our civilization risks losing many tangible aspects of its heritage. While these traditions may be considered intangible, their absence would lead to the loss of significant, concrete (tangible) elements. For instance, if we disregard the sacredness associated with Marutvamala, it could be treated merely as another hill subject to quarrying, resulting in the disappearance of the 118 species of herbs that thrive there. This highlights the importance of Indian Knowledge Systems. We must identify and recognize these systems within our texts, lives, and history. It is essential to convey their relevance to the current generation and help them integrate these teachings into their daily lives.

Promoting Theodiversity

As we explore the Indian Knowledge System, it is vital to consider the values that need to be upheld. One important civilizational value of India is theodiversity. We must bring to people's attention

what theodiversity is, why it needs preservation, and what challenges it faces. Just as biodiversity is currently threatened, so too is theodiversity. It is essential to teach this through Indian Knowledge Systems.

When we discuss theodiversity, we acknowledge that there are multiple perspectives from which to view the universe. The same phenomenon can be interpreted through different approaches. This multi-dimensionality inherent in theodiversity empowers individuals to perceive various dimensions of reality. When theodiversity is diminished, we risk losing our ability to appreciate these diverse perspectives, leading to a unidimensional worldview.

Theodiversity embodies the understanding that a particular phenomenon can manifest in many forms—this principle can be encapsulated in the phrase "Unity in Diversity". This foundational law discovered by the Indian civilization is paramount; it underscores the survival of human beings as a species and helps prevent self-destruction in the name of religion, civilization, or racial superiority.

As Bhagavan Sri Krishna articulates, a truly liberated or enlightened individual perceives both the one and the many. Such individuals witness and experience this process, becoming liberators themselves. It is crucial to grasp this clear statement of "unity in diversity", which should be recognized and emphasised at all levels of education and society.

Recently, a group of terrorists invaded a country, leading to the slaughter of innocent people. In retaliation, entire towns and cities were devastated, resulting in immense human suffering. This violence stems from one religious group's inability to tolerate another despite both sharing a common belief system. Although

they worship the same God and adhere to similar principles, conflict arises simply because they refer to God by different names. If the same mindset were present in India, imagine the number of genocides we would have witnessed. Those who worship Shiva might turn against those who worship Vishnu. But it doesn't happen here, why so?

When someone once asked Ramana Maharshi why he sang only for Arunachala Shiva and not for Nataraja Shiva, he explained that, while Nataraja dances, the mountain stands alone, deserving his focus. If we adopt this mindset, we might see that the Shiva devotees of Nataraja could oppose those who worship Arunachala. A notable example is the Vaishnava poet Pillai Perumala Iyengar, who exclusively praised Srirangam Rangaswami Vishnu and not Venkatachalapathi Vishnu. When questioned about this choice, he offered a seemingly casual response highlighting an important psychological principle: the human mind seeks out differences and creates divisions.

Our tradition includes such anecdotes to illustrate the absurdity of this tendency, often presenting it in a humorous light. We must recognize that this diversity should not lead to theological conflicts; instead, we should celebrate the importance of theodiversity and the principle of unity in diversity that has been discovered in our land.

All evolution exhibits the same underlying principle, 'unity in diversity'. For example, Erwin Schrödinger's book "What is Life?" became the basis for the discovery of DNA. The problem in genetics is that the genetic material should be consistent, generation after generation, yet have the capacity to create variations. This duality (seemingly contradictory) is present in

diverse ways, and contemplating this, Schrödinger writes about the unitary nature of consciousness. This book, "What is Life," became the catalyst for the discovery of DNA's structure. Though Francis Crick and James Watson have not explored Vedanta, it was Vedanta that gave insights to Schrödinger to write "What is Life." This is an example of how theodiversity can then lead to unity.

Rational Enquiry vs. Personal Devotion

The human search for divinity is often a tumultuous journey, filled with inner conflicts and confusion. On one hand, the abstract, intellectual appeal of a universal conception of God captivates the mind. Yet, when faced with life's struggles, the need for a personal, tangible deity arises, offering solace and support. This dichotomy can lead to uncertainty and doubt, wondering whether the universal or personal aspects of divinity should be embraced.

Here IKS provides a beautiful binary of Nirguna Brahman and Saguna Brahman. This binary is a perfect representation of how a formless, abstract concept of God (Nirguna Brahman) can coexist harmoniously with a personalised, accessible deity (Saguna Brahman). Like two sides of the same coin, both are valid, interconnected ways to approach divinity, resolving inner conflicts and fostering unity within diverse spiritual traditions.

The timeless wisdom of IKS offers a path to reconciliation between the universal and the personal aspects of God. As individuals embrace both Nirguna and Saguna Brahman, they are able to appreciate the divine from diverse perspectives. The intimacy of a personal deity allows for a meaningful, emotionally resonant connection, while the universal aspects of divinity provide a wider, intellectual understanding of reality. This dual

approach offers a comprehensive spiritual framework that caters to the diverse needs and inclinations of humanity.

The duality of Nirguna and Saguna Brahman not only resolves internal conflicts within individuals, but also creates a bridge between diverse spiritual traditions. The universal, abstract conception of Nirguna Brahman allows for open dialogues and shared understandings across different religions. Meanwhile, the personal, accessible nature of Saguna Brahman ensures that spiritual practices remain intimately tied to cultural traditions. This perspective, deeply rooted in Indian Knowledge Systems, has the potential to nurture understanding and inclusivity within our diverse, multi-faith world.

Conclusion

The spirit of Indian Knowledge Systems (IKS) beckons us to rediscover a deeper, living truth that connects with the challenges and aspirations of our present while guiding us toward a shared, harmonious future. Beyond preserving ancient wisdom, IKS offers a holistic, innovative vision of life that merges rational inquiry, spirituality, creativity, service, and ecological consciousness. At its heart is a dynamic understanding of unity and diversity, providing a foundation for sustainable development, coexistence, and cultural richness.

The mission of IKS, therefore, is not merely about revisiting the past but about engaging with it in a conscious way that informs and shapes our present. Through stories, practices, and philosophies, it encourages us to dive deeper into our collective history, uncovering insights that can help us navigate the challenges of the modern world. The wisdom of IKS, like Marutvamala's ecological balance, or the diversity of our

religious traditions, holds the potential for a richer, more inclusive world.

As we stand at the intersection of globalization, technology, and ecological crisis, IKS beckons us to explore a fundamental question, "How can we harness the brilliance of our ancestral knowledge to foster a world where individuality and interconnectedness thrive?" It is not just an academic inquiry but a moral imperative for our collective existence. By embracing the wisdom of IKS, we honour our shared humanity and commit ourselves to a path of truth, diversity, and universal well-being.

Chapter 6

ULTIMATE REALITY: DIFFERENT PERSPECTIVES

SOORAJ SUBRAHMANYAN

Oh my God! There are a million things that we can perceive directly with our senses. But we are still curious about something that is beyond our sensory experiences. Since our childhood, we have been familiar with the term God. We are influenced by God-related rituals, prayers, festivals, and beliefs throughout our lives, from our daily routine to our entire lives. Some people believe in God, while others reject or doubt the existence of God. There have been talks, discussions, debates, and even brutal fights in the name of God. To discuss something, negate or affirm it, we need to have a common, agreeable definition. However, in the case of God, do we have one?

Once, a renowned German philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche made a statement that became very popular, "God is dead". Negation of God has been prominent in the works of many of the European philosophers, thinkers, and scientists after the Enlightenment era. In Europe, the Renaissance was a period of cultural and

intellectual revival that began in the 14th century. It set the stage for the Enlightenment, which emerged in the 17th and 18th centuries and used reason and science to challenge traditional beliefs and improve society. These two periods together helped revive Europe from the Dark Ages[1] when religious dogma and authoritarianism overshadowed reason and freedom.

If observed closely, it is clear that thinkers and philosophers such as Nietzsche are critiquing the concept of God as understood during Europe's Dark Ages. During that time, the prevalent notion of God resembled that of a supreme dictator - who is wrathful towards non-believers and those who worship other "false gods."[2] Can we generalize that idea of God to countless spiritual and religious concepts around the world? This today is a common mistake, arising from Eurocentric worldviews, while negating or affirming our idea of God, which is often limited to the idea of God prevalent in Europe during the Dark Ages.

Creator and Creation

Why do we need a God, or how did the concept of God come to exist? As rational beings, our natural tendency is to seek patterns. So we observed the pattern of 'cause and effect'. Every event, process, state, or object is the contribution of some other event, process, state, or object. These patterns of cause and

[1] The period from about 500 to 1000 CE, often referred to as the Dark Ages, is characterized by cultural and economic decline. During this time, dogmatic religious institutions exerted significant influence over intellectual and cultural life, and their control was at its peak. During the dark age, total faith was preferred over reason and logic.

[2] Many religions consider their god as the one true God, and reject all other gods of all other religions as false gods.

effect led humans to another big question, "What is the primary cause?" To create a tiny needle or a huge palace, some sort of intelligence is necessary, so what would be the intelligence behind the creation and sustenance of this extremely complex and well-ordered universe? This question led to numerous stories, beliefs, religions, rituals, and revelations. If we look into the different religions and cultures, they all have their own creation stories and creator Gods. Some believe that there was an entity—God—and that He created the entire universe. Others disagree with this; they negated this idea of God; they said if God can exist without any other cause, then it would be the same for the universe; it can also exist without any creator. Another set of people agree with the idea of God, but they have objections to the name of God; according to them, their God is the 'real' God. In this manner, there are multiple perspectives and concepts about God.

Historically speaking, the prominence of these different theological and religious viewpoints has often been determined by their political power rather than their rationality. If one group comes into power, they try to discredit the belief in another God(s). Especially during the Dark Ages, inquisitions, religious wars, and activities such as witch-hunts were widely used to enforce belief systems on people.

God in India

However, if we look at India, it has been home to different theological and philosophical positions. One of the main reasons is that Indian knowledge systems give more importance to living according to Dharma than worshipping or believing in any particular entity. The Rishis (seers) of ancient India explored all the possibilities of the primary causes of creation.

sustenance, and dissolution of the universe. They do not believe in the idea that some God sitting in the sky created and governs the universe to solve the question. Such concepts are riddled with fallacies. For instance, one might argue that if God created the universe, where was God before its creation? A theory could be made about God's existence in another realm or heaven, but then who created that realm? Was it God's creation too? If so, then where could have God existed before the creation of that realm? This is an infinite regress fallacy. If God is the creator, then who created God? Is there another higher God? This leads to the question that if God can exist without a creator, wouldn't it also be possible for the universe to exist without a creator?

According to Rishis, God is not creating this world as an artist paints a painting. But the supreme reality is manifested as the universe, just like a dancer's dance. Dance is not different from the dancer; similarly, the universe is not a separate entity from the supreme reality but an expression of it. Upanishads explain it through a beautiful analogy: "As a spider projects forth and draws back (its threads), the universe emerges from the imperishable being"[3]. The creator is not a person or entity that sits in some other world and governs the universe, but God pervades everywhere and everything. The Ishavasya Upanishad begins with the following mantra,

ईशावास्यमिदं सर्वं यत्किञ्च जगत्यां जगत् ।

Īśāvāsyam idam sarvaṁ yat kiñca jagatyāṁ jagat

All that exists in the universe should be covered by the Ishvara.

Ishavasya Upanishad 1

[3] "yathorṇa-nābhiḥ sṛjate gṛhṇate ca," Mundakaupanishad, 1.1.7

Usually, we translate Ishvara, Bhagavan, etc. as God. However, Indian ideas are completely different from the Dark Ages' concept of God. For instance, in the above verse, Īśā or Ishvara is the ruler of the universe, but it is not a separate being. Īśā is the real self of every creature (Commentary by Shankaracharya), and it pervades everything. That is completely different from the idea of a heavenly monarch.

> **Activity:** Explore the etymological meanings of Ishvara, Bhagavan, and God.

Sadguru Sri Mata Amritanandamayi Devi says, "There is no need to search for a God sitting somewhere beyond the sky. God is the all-pervading Supreme Consciousness."

In the Bhagavata Purana, when the evil king Hiranyakashipu asked his son Prahlada where his Narayana was, Prahlada, devoted to Narayana, replied that Narayana is everywhere. In anger, Hiranyakashipu broke a nearby pillar, challenging Narayana's presence. Suddenly, Narayana appeared as Narasimha, protecting Prahlada. Prahlada understood that the supreme being is not confined to time or place but is all-pervading.

Many Gods!

If the ultimate reality, Ishvara, transcends all limitations, such as names and forms, then why are there so many Gods in Indian culture?

There is no denying that humans possess the most advanced brains and an unfathomable ability to think. However, those are limited in many ways. With our limited reason and senses, it is hard to understand the unlimited and absolute reality. Since Isvara is our innermost self, we cannot know it by objectifying

it. So the ancient Rishis presented Ishvara on many levels for the benefit of people belonging to different intellectual levels. All the different deities we come across in Indian culture are nothing but different manifestations of the same.

We have in the Rigveda,

इन्द्रं मित्रं वरुणमग्निमाहुरथो दिव्यः स सुपर्णो गरुत्मान् ।
एकं सद्विप्रा बहुधा वदन्त्यग्निं यमं मातरिश्वानमाहुः ।।

Indraṃ mitraṃ varuṇamagnimāhuratho
divyaḥ sa suparṇo garutmān .
Ekaṃ sadviprā bahudhā vadantyagniṃ
yamaṃ mātariśvānamāhuḥ

They call it Indra, Mitra, Varuna, Agni,
and he is the heavenly-winged Garutman.
To what is One, sages give many a title,
they call it Agni, Yama, Matarisvan.

Rig Veda 1.164.46

Acharya Yaska, the commentator of the Veda, also says,

एकस्यात्मनोऽन्ये देवाः प्रत्यङ्गानि भवन्ति

ekasyātmano'nye devāḥ pratyaṅgāni bhavanti

Many forms of Gods are manifestations of One Reality

Nirukta, Yaska

One can choose any deity as a favorite deity or Ishta devata according to his/her mental and spiritual orientation. For a devotee, Ishtadevata is Supreme Reality itself, and all other deities are nothing but different manifestations of the Ishta Devata.

Indian Knowledge Systems have historically promoted intellectual debates and discussions regarding the existence as well as the

nature of the supreme being. Among the diverse philosophical traditions, the Charvaka school rejected the existence of Isvara, advocating a materialistic worldview that is centred on the principle of living only once (akin to the modern concept of "YOLO"). Philosophers such as Shankara and other Acharyas critically engaged with and refuted these arguments. These rebuttals were based on logic and reason, not dogma or political authority of the Dark Ages of Europe.

The story of the debate between Acharya Shankara Bhagavadpada and Acharya Mandana Mishra is worth recalling here. Both of these Acharyas were proponents of distinct philosophies. When they decided to engage in a debate, they requested Mandana Mishra's wife, Ubhayabharati, to be the judge. She gave two flower garlands to the two Acharyas to wear, stating that whichever garland withered first would indicate the failure of that Acharya in the debate. She also thoroughly monitored the logical development of the debate. In the end, Sankaracharya won the debate, and Mandana Mishra followed Sankaracharya's philosophy.

- What are the things you can understand from this story about India's debate tradition?
- What might be the reason Ubhayabharati considered the withering of the garland a sign of failure?

Here, even though Ubhayabharati was the wife of the opponent, Sankaracharya was sure about her intellectual clarity and neutrality in judgment. A debate is intended to know the truth, and the scholars should present their viewpoints without losing their mental peace. If any of the debaters lost their tranquility of mind, it would raise their

body temperature, affecting the flowers in their garland. The fresh flowers symbolize the debater's peaceful mind. Clashes of different schools of thought about the ultimate reality led to wars and bloodshed, causing millions of deaths worldwide. Here in India, Ubhayabharati taught the world another way of interaction between philosophies.

In short, ancient Indians don't believe in a supreme monarch who sits on a mighty throne and either promotes us to heaven if we believe in him or sends us to eternal hell if we do not believe in him/her. We owe this to the diversity and pluralism that we are experiencing today. According to Indian traditions, the supreme being can assume any name and form. There is no point in fighting each other to prove one's god is the true God. For them, Brahman is the substratum of everything; it is the thread that is strung together in the universe[4].

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[4] mattaḥ parataraṁ nānyat kiñchid asti dhanañjaya mayi sarvam idaṁ protaṁ sūtre maṇi-gaṇā iva, SBG 7.7